I Wanted to Grow Old with You (A Collection on Divorce)

By Jeredith Merrin, Gabeba Baderoon, Melissa Stein, Tony Hoagland and Jack Gilbert

INTRODUCTION

Almost everyone wants a happy marriage and wants it to last a lifetime. Divorce is a scary thing to think about, so we tend to assume people will tolerate a lot of marital problems before starting to consider it. But most also know the scary U.S. statistics: nearly 50 percent of first marriages and more than 60 percent of second marriages end in divorce.

I Wanted to Grow Old with You is a collection of poetry on the theme . . . Divorce

Family Reunion by Jeredith Merrin

The divorced mother and her divorcing
daughter. The about-to-be ex-son-in-law
and the ex-husband's adopted son.
The divorcing daughter's child, who is

the step-nephew of the ex-husband's

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adopted son. Everyone cordial:
the ex-husband's second wife
friendly to the first wife, warm

to the divorcing daughter's child's
great-grandmother, who was herself
long ago divorced. Everyone
grown used to the idea of divorce.

Almost everyone has separated
from the landscape of a childhood.
Collections of people in cities
are divorced from clean air and stars.

Toddlers in day care are parted
from working parents, schoolchildren
from the assumption of unbloodied
daylong safety. Old people die apart

from all they've gathered over time,
and in strange beds. Adults

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grow estranged from a God
evidently divorced from History;

most are cut off from their own
histories, each of which waits
like a child left at day care.
What if you turned back for a moment

and put your arms around yours?
Yes, you might be late for work;
no, your history doesn't smell sweet
like a toddler's head. But look

at those small round wrists,
that short-legged, comical walk.
Caress your history--who else will?
Promise to come back later.

Pay attention when it asks you
simple questions: Where are we going?
Is it scary? What happened? Can

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I have more now? Who is that?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jeredith Merrin
Book: Bat Ode
ISBN: 978-0226520582
Publisher: University of Chicago Press
Date (Month/Year): April 2001

Old Photographs by Gabeba Baderoon

On my desk is a photograph of you
taken by the woman who loved you then.

In some photos her shadow falls
in the foreground. In this one,
her body is not that far from yours.

Did you hold your head that way
because she loved it?

She is not invisible, not
my enemy,

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nor even the past.

I think

I love the things she loved.

Of all your old photographs, I wanted

this one for its becoming. I think

you were starting

to turn your head a little,

your eyes looking slightly to the side.

Was this the beginning of leaving?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Gabeba Baderoon
Book: So Much Things to Say
ISBN: 978-1936070077
Publisher: Akashic Books
Date (Month/Year): July 1, 2010

Ring by Melissa Stein

Control was all

I wanted: a handle

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on the day, the night

when it curved,

when it swayed,

when I could sense

the teeming stars

in light, in dark

the sun's bare wire.

Some switch

to turn it off:

each shadow

pinned to each tree

like a radius

of some infant's

milk it spilled.

And the leaves,

their gossip

of claw and beak

and wind and heat

and wing. Tether

lake to bank and

cloud to peak.

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And weather it.

Weather it. All this

to say I've

taken off my ring.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Melissa Stein
Book: Terrible Blooms
ISBN: 978-1556595295
Publisher: Copper Canyon Press
Date (Month/Year): April 2018

In Praise of Their Divorce Tony Hoagland

And when I heard about the divorce of my friends,

I couldn't help but be proud of them,

that man and that woman setting off in different

directions,

like pilgrims in a proverb

—him to buy his very own toaster oven,

her seeking a prescription for sleeping pills.

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Let us keep in mind the hidden forces

which had struggled underground for years

to push their way to the surface—and that finally did,

cracking the crust, moving the plates of earth apart,

releasing the pent-up energy required

for them to rent their own apartments,

for her to join the softball league for single mothers

for him to read George the Giraffe over his

speakerphone

at bedtime to the six-year-old.

The bible says, Be fruitful and multiply

but is it not also fruitful to subtract and to divide?

Because if marriage is a kind of womb,

divorce is the being born again;

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alimony is the placenta one of them will eat;

loneliness is the name of the wet-nurse;
regret is the elementary school;

endurance is the graduation.
So do not say that they are splattered like dropped
lasagna

or dead in the head-on collision of clichés
or nailed on the cross of their competing narratives.

What is taken apart is not utterly demolished.
It is like a great mysterious egg in Kansas

that has cracked and hatched two big bewildered birds.
It is two spaceships coming out of retirement,

flying away from their dead world,
the burning booster rocket of divorce
falling off behind them,

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the bystanders pointing at the sky and saying, Look.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tony Hoagland
Book: Unincorporated Persons in the Late Honda Dynasty
ISBN: 978-1555975494
Publisher: Graywolf Press
Date (Month/Year): February 2010

Failing and Flying Jack Gilbert

Everyone forgets that Icarus also flew.
It's the same when love comes to an end,
or the marriage fails and people say
they knew it was a mistake, that everybody
said it would never work. That she was
old enough to know better. But anything
worth doing is worth doing badly.
Like being there by that summer ocean
on the other side of the island while
love was fading out of her, the stars
burning so extravagantly those nights that
anyone could tell you they would never last.
Every morning she was asleep in my bed

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like a visitation, the gentleness in her
like antelope standing in the dawn mist.
Each afternoon I watched her coming back
through the hot stony field after swimming,
the sea light behind her and the huge sky
on the other side of that. Listened to her
while we ate lunch. How can they say
the marriage failed? Like the people who
came back from Provence (when it was Provence)
and said it was pretty but the food was greasy.
I believe Icarus was not failing as he fell,
but just coming to the end of his triumph.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jack Gilbert
Book: Refusing Heaven
ISBN: 978-0375710858
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): March 2007

AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier

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